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RARING TO RETURN
Former BJP CM Raman Singh (left)

THE BJP EFFECTIVELY FLAGGED THE BAGHEL GOVT'S FAILURE TO PAY ITS SHARE UNDER THE PMAY SCHEME; THERE'S ALSO A POTENT THIRD FRONT TO CONTEND WITH

candidate even as the BJP declared its nominees on 85 of the 90 seats by October 9. In fact, the saffron party was first off the mark, coming out with its first list of 21 candidates on August 17, well before the announcement of the poll schedule. Though it has refrained from projecting any CM face, the second round of ticket distribution on October 9 shows a clear tilt towards Raman Singh. But the moot question is: can the 70-year-old veteran, who has been feeling quite marginalised of late, now give the BJP's campaign a new lease of life?

What could help the BJP cause is the infighting among senior Congressmen. Even as the high command intervened a few months ago to broker peace between Baghel, his baiter T.S. Singhdeo and the then PCC president Mohan Markam, hidden undercurrents remain. As part of the new arrangement, Singhdeo was appointed as the deputy chief minister while Markam, who was inducted into the cabinet, vacated the PCC chief post for Deepak Baij. But recent public statements by Baghel and Singhdeo—even at the India Today State of the State Chhattisgarh First Conclave in Raipur on September 30—hint at a lingering bitterness.

Baghel may also face a backlash in urban areas, where many voters feel that the government is more concerned about putting extra cash in the hands of the rural folk. The BJP has effectively flagged the Chhattisgarh government's failure to pay its share under the Prime Minister Awas Yojana (PMAY), thus denying affordable housing to lakhs of intended beneficiaries in lower- and middle-income groups. "The denial of PMAY dwellings is the single biggest issue the BJP will capitalise on," says political analyst Sudeep Shrivastava. "The Congress has tried to take corrective measures by coming up with its own housing scheme (Gramin Awas Nyay Yojana announced in July). It has also identified around one lakh beneficiaries. But it remains to be seen if it's too little, too late."

Besides all this, there are serious allegations of corruption against key functionaries of the ruling party and senior bureaucrats. With the BJP-ruled Centre's enforcement agencies going into overdrive since October last year, two Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officers have landed in jail.

Another factor that could upset Baghel's calculations is the fairly potent third front in Chhattisgarh. In the 2018 assembly election, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and Janta Congress Chhattisgarh (JCC) alliance had won seven seats, and secured a nearly 12 per cent vote share. This time, the JCC, founded by the late former CM Ajit Jogi, is in disarray, but the BSP and the Jogi family command the loyalty of a section of the 13 per cent SC vote. Also, the Sarv Adivasi Samaj, an umbrella organisation of tribal groups led by former Congress veteran Arvind Netam, has launched its political front, Hamar Raj Party, and is planning to contest more than 50 seats. Any dent in the tribal vote will only add to the Congress's woes. "Chhattisgarh has a tradition of closely contested elections except in 2018," says Shrivastava. "The victory margin will not be that huge for whosoever wins this time." Can Baghel prove the 2018 results were not an aberration? ■